Agentic commerce

A visual field guide for a business-facing product manager.

From selling a product to completing an intent.

INTENT	ACTION	OUTCOME
"Help me choose." →	Compare. Verify. Act. →	An order that works.

The PM thesis

Start with a narrow shopping job and a reliable handoff. Earn more autonomy only when consent, product data, payments and recovery work together.

15-20 minute read. Global examples + India lens. Proposed product choices are labelled; no speculative market-size charts.

[1] OpenAI: product discovery [4] Shopify: commerce agent docs [8] IMF: agentic AI and payments

Agentic does not mean fully autonomous

AI plans and coordinates steps toward a commerce outcome. The amount it may do is a product decision.

01

Advice

Answers questions and explains products.

No order authority.

02

Assisted shopping

Compares options; prepares cart or handoff.

User checks out.

03

Approved execution

Acts after approval of a specific order.

Approval binds to this order.

04

Bounded delegation

Acts later within an explicit mandate.

Limits, expiry and revocation.

Conceptual ladder, not an industry standard. A chatbot interface alone does not prove end-to-end task completion.

[6] AP2: v0.2 specification [8] IMF: agentic AI and payments

One intent.
Many failure points.

Illustrative job: "Find headphones for calls, within my budget, delivered before my trip."

1 ↓

Clarify

Confirm budget, fit and delivery deadline.

Risk: solve the wrong need.

2 ↓

Compare

Explain shortlist tradeoffs using evidence.

Risk: invent compatibility or reviews.

3 ↓

Verify

Recheck variant, stock, total and arrival.

Risk: stale price or wrong variant.

4 ↓

Approve + buy

Show the exact order and payment scope.

Risk: approval does not match the charge.

5

Close the loop

Confirm order, then track changes and recovery.

Risk: "paid" is mistaken for "ordered."

PM implication: conversion alone misses intent errors, delivery failures and the cost of fixing them.

[2] OpenAI: shopping help [4] Shopify: commerce agent docs [6] AP2: v0.2 specification

What real products show us

Source-verified capabilities are not a guarantee of access for every user, merchant or country.

OpenAI / ChatGPT

March 2026: richer visual discovery and ACP feeds; merchant checkout and a Walmart app path. Current help still describes Instant Checkout for some eligible products. [1, 2]

Google / Search + Gemini

May 2026: Universal Cart and UCP checkout features announced with staged retailer and market rollouts. Retailers remain merchant of record. Do not infer universal access. [5]

Shopify / commerce infrastructure

Current docs: catalog search, carts, checkout handoff and direct completion for trusted agents; order events. Universal Cart API is labelled early access. [4]

Lesson: distribution, merchant access and checkout control matter as much as model quality. No adoption or uplift is inferred.

[1] OpenAI: product discovery [2] OpenAI: shopping help [4] Shopify: commerce agent docs [5] Google: UCP shopping updates

Different layers.
Not interchangeable.

Read protocols by the job they solve, rather than as one winner-takes-all acronym race.

ACP / Agentic Commerce Protocol

OpenAI March update extends ACP for discovery, feeds and promotions. It is not a universal payment rail. [1]

UCP / Universal Commerce Protocol

Discovery, checkout and order lifecycle. Merchants expose supported capabilities; transport can use APIs, MCP or A2A. [3, 4]

MCP / Model Context Protocol

UCP can use MCP to connect agents to tools. MCP alone does not define a complete commerce journey. [3]

AP2 / Agent Payments Protocol

v0.2 defines linked Checkout and Payment Mandates and receipts. Authorization evidence, not a settlement network. [6]

Version matters: older AP2 explainers may use different mandate names. Protocol support does not imply all features are enabled.

[1] OpenAI: product discovery [3] Google: UCP technical overview [6] AP2: v0.2 specification

Let AI reason.
Let rules authorize.

Conceptual architecture: keep uncertain reasoning away from irreversible financial execution.

1 / Intent + orchestration

Agent interprets needs, compares items and proposes an order.

↓

2 / Policy + authorization

Deterministic checks: identity, mandate, total, limits, expiry and risk.

↓

3 / Commerce + payment execution

Merchant confirms order; payment systems process the authorized instruction.

Evidence and recovery span every layer

Log intent → quote → approval → charge → order → refund. Reconcile uncertain outcomes before retrying.

Synthesis informed by AP2, IMF and NPCI. A valid mandate does not prove the agent selected a suitable product.

[6] AP2: v0.2 specification [8] IMF: agentic AI and payments [9] NPCI: Architecture of Trust

Design for the moment something goes wrong

Controls are part of the user experience, not a compliance screen added after checkout.

Wrong item or substitution

Bind approval to SKU, variant and quantity.

Review again when a material field changes.

Stale price or stock

Refresh authoritative merchant data before commit.

Requote full total and delivery terms.

Malicious product content

Treat pages and reviews as data, not instructions.

Block content from changing tools or payees.

Duplicate or uncertain charge

Use idempotency; reconcile order and payment state.

Do not retry blindly after a timeout.

Misuse of delegated authority

Limit merchant, amount, category, duration and purpose.

Make pause, revoke, support and refunds visible.

Proposed controls, not a legal checklist. Liability, redress and data handling require market-specific review.

[6] AP2: v0.2 specification [8] IMF: agentic AI and payments

UPI scale is not proof of agentic readiness

Separate national payment rails, agent authorization standards and merchant willingness to accept agents.

10 SEP 2026

NPCI: principles, not a launch notice

Official keynote says NPCI is examining agent protocols and calls for bounded, accountable mandates. [9]

10 SEP 2026

Reuters: a planned agent registry

Reports a proposed verification registry; liability still needs regulation. Unnamed sources, not launch confirmation. [11]

12 SEP 2026

Business Standard: launch put on hold

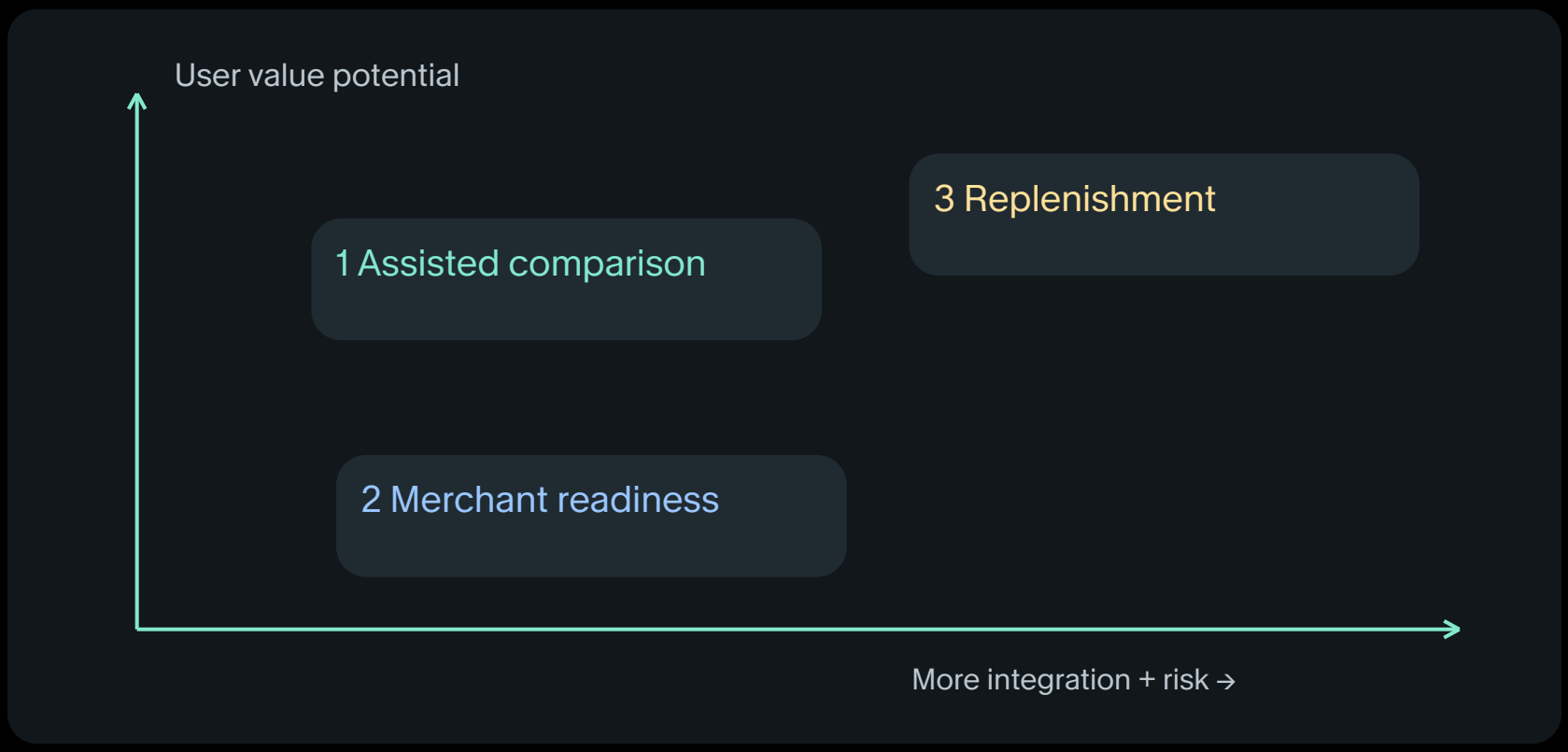
Reports UAP delayed pending safeguards and regulatory clearance. Later evidence than early-September launch expectations. [10]

No broad UAP launch was verified in inspected sources. Before an India payment MVP, verify current PSP, bank, merchant and regulatory support.

[9] NPCI: Architecture of Trust [10] Business Standard: UAP delay [11] Reuters: planned AI registry

Where a PM can create value first

Proposed priorities for an unspecified commerce team. Positions in the map are qualitative judgments, not measured data.



Recommended sequence

1 / Assisted comparison + handoff

Resolve a difficult choice using verified product data and merchant checkout.

2 / Merchant readiness as B2B alternative

Improve catalog quality, inventory freshness and agent-facing capabilities.

3 / Bounded replenishment later

Requires mandates, revocation, substitutions policy and reliable payment access.

Do not start with unrestricted "buy anything for me." Pick the user pain and access you can actually serve.

[1] OpenAI: product discovery [4] Shopify: commerce agent docs [6] AP2: v0.2 specification

A decision agent, not a universal buyer

Proposed wedge: work-headphone selection from one partner merchant. A deliberately narrow illustrative scope.

User promise

"Find a shortlist for my calls, budget and delivery needs; I review the order."

Minimum data

Variants, compatibility, stock, total, delivery estimates and return terms.

In scope

Guided questions → evidence-backed shortlist → refreshed quote → merchant checkout handoff → order confirmation if tracking access exists.

Out of scope

Unapproved payments, multi-merchant carts, automatic substitutions.

Acceptance test

If price or variant changes, block the old handoff and request review.

Catalog access is a go/no-go dependency. A working prototype does not establish production merchant access or order tracking.

[2] OpenAI: shopping help [4] Shopify: commerce agent docs

Optimize for orders people still want

Suggested framework. Set targets from your own baseline; these are not industry benchmarks.

North star: successful-intent rate

Eligible tasks ending in a confirmed, constraint-matching order with no attributable agent error in a defined follow-up window ÷ all eligible tasks.

Funnel

Intent clarified
↓
Shortlist accepted
↓
Handoff opened
↓
Order verified

Guardrails

Wrong variants

Unauthorized acts

Duplicate charges

Returns + complaints

Operations

Data freshness

Tool failure rate

Resolution time

Cost per success

Experiment design

Randomize eligible sessions against the current flow. Measure full-journey outcomes and contribution, not only shortlist clicks.

Define eligibility before testing. Count unverified orders separately; checkout clicks are not purchases. Error attribution needs review.

[8] IMF: agentic AI and payments

More conversion can still mean less value

Include service, error and return costs in the business case, not just gross merchandise value.

Incremental contribution

= incremental order margin or revenue
− (AI + tool cost) − extra support − refunds/fraud/error losses

Buyer assistant

Subscription or service fee.

Risk: willingness to pay; high task cost.

Merchant channel

Referral or conversion fee.

Risk: ranking bias; margin pressure; attribution.

Infrastructure

API or platform fee.

Risk: integration cost; reliability; slow sales.

Demand test

Does the user return for the same job without a subsidy?

Business models are options, not current vendor pricing. Keep sponsored placement separate from suitability and organic ranking.

[1] OpenAI: product discovery [8] IMF: agentic AI and payments

A six-week plan with stop gates

Illustrative plan, contingent on an available merchant integration, support coverage and team capacity.

WEEKS 1-2

Prove the problem

Interview target shoppers, review failed journeys and test a manually verified shortlist. Stop if the task is rare or not painful.

WEEKS 3-4

Prove the plumbing

Integrate one catalog and checkout handoff. Test price changes, variant errors, timeouts and malicious product text. Stop if data is unreliable.

WEEKS 5-6

Prove incremental value

Pilot against the existing flow. Compare successful-intent rate, contribution and error burden. Expand only if value survives the costs.

Set outcome and cost thresholds before testing. No known critical authorization defect at launch; zero observed errors does not prove zero risk.

Turn this into your own product bet

A suggested 30-minute exercise with design, engineering, risk and operations.

5 min / Choose one intent

Who is the shopper? What difficult or repeated job are they trying to finish?

10 min / Draw the boundary

Mark what AI can propose, prepare or execute. Name exactly where approval is needed.

10 min / Break the journey

Change price, remove stock, insert malicious content, time out payment. Who owns recovery?

5 min / Define success

Pick one user outcome, one economic measure and the error that blocks release.

One user + one intent + one authority boundary.

Takeaway: agentic commerce is a trust-and-execution product, not a chat interface with a payment button.

Product + protocol evidence

All sources were opened and inspected. Tap a title to read the original.

[1] OpenAI: product discovery

24 Mar 2026

Official announcement: discovery feeds, merchant checkout, Walmart app.

[2] OpenAI: shopping help

Current help, undated

Current help: eligibility, prices and unverified review summaries.

[3] Google: UCP technical overview

11 Jan 2026

Technical source: capabilities, transport and merchant responsibilities.

[4] Shopify: commerce agent docs

Current developer docs

Developer docs: carts, checkout, order events; some access restricted.

[5] Google: UCP shopping updates

20 May 2026

Official announcement: Universal Cart and staged checkout rollouts.

[6] AP2: v0.2 specification

Current specification

Primary specification: mandates, receipts and deterministic validation.

Documentation describes capability, not adoption. Availability is merchant-, account- and geography-dependent.

Policy, India and reading cautions

Current to 23 October 2026. Undated pages are identified as current documentation, not dated announcements.

[7] Google: AP2 and FIDO

28 Apr 2026

Official announcement: AP2 donation and human-not-present updates.

[8] IMF: agentic AI and payments

24 Apr 2026

Policy research: reasoning, authorization and settlement separation.

[9] NPCI: Architecture of Trust

10 Sep 2026 keynote

Official keynote: bounded mandates; agent protocols under examination.

[10] Business Standard: UAP delay

Updated 12 Sep 2026

Independent reporting: UAP launch delayed; unnamed sources.

[11] Reuters: planned AI registry

10 Sep 2026

Independent reporting: planned registry; unresolved liability questions.

Reading cautions

Diagrams are conceptual. Priorities, metrics and MVP plans are proposed PM choices. No legal advice or guaranteed rollout dates.

Uncertainty preserved: selective checkout, staged rollouts and no verified broad UAP launch. Recheck before product or payment commitments.